

Curriculum Policy

Version 3 · August 2026 · for review and adoption by the Governing Body

Supersedes the policy approved on 1 September 2025. Reviewed annually. A summary of what has changed in this version, and why, is issued alongside it.

1. What we mean by curriculum

At Emmanuel Christian School we define curriculum as the complete, holistic experience of a child. We insist that our children are the best they can be in every aspect of their life, that they strive for the highest standards and “work heartily as for the Lord” to achieve their maximum God-given potential.

Our curriculum is designed to reach the heart and mind of each child in order to shape their character and progress their academic ability. We aim to develop children into successful, physically and emotionally healthy adults who will appreciate differences in society and contribute to their community and the wider world by being the people God intended them to be and carrying out His purposes.

2. The Christian basis of our curriculum

Emmanuel is a Christian school, and that shapes what we teach and how, not only the assemblies that surround it. Our conviction is that the Christian faith should be the main ingredient of every subject rather than a decoration applied to any of them.

Every subject has a written biblical rationale. Each is one page and answers the same four questions: what this subject reveals of God, our convictions for teaching it, which biblical themes it carries most, and what that means in practice. These are written with the teachers who teach the subject, quality-assured by the Headteacher, and reviewed as the curriculum develops. They are the reason a parent, a governor or an inspector can ask why we teach something the way we do and receive an answer that is written down rather than improvised.

Six biblical themes run through every subject, giving the whole curriculum one theological grammar:

Theme	Core conviction
Creation & order	The universe is the ordered, intelligible work of a faithful Creator; study is discovery, not invention
Image & creativity	People are image-bearers: rational, moral, creative, relational
Fall & discernment	Creation and culture are marred; pupils learn to test everything
Redemption & hope	History is held within God’s redemptive story; failure is not final; work can be restored
Wisdom & truth	Truth exists and can be known; wisdom is skill in living before God
Stewardship & service	Gifts, money, creation and skill are held in trust for God and neighbour

Three commitments that govern how convictions are taught

Truth. Pupils are taught the school’s biblical convictions clearly, and taught accurately what the law of England and the academic disciplines say, including where these differ. We do not blur either.

Grace. Every person is treated with dignity and respect. Pupils learn to hold conviction and compassion together, to disagree well, and to love neighbours who believe differently.

Rigour. Statutory content, examination specifications and the full demands of each discipline are taught in full.

Distinctiveness is never an excuse for a thinner curriculum. Where required content is interpreted differently by

Christians — evolution in science being the clearest example — it is taught fully and accurately as the discipline holds it, the school's convictions are taught clearly as the school's convictions, and pupils learn how Christians relate the two.

A pupil's faith is never assessed, in any subject, at any point. We assess knowledge, understanding and application. A pupil who does not share the school's beliefs can achieve the highest outcomes by explaining them accurately and engaging with them thoughtfully.

3. How the curriculum is organised

The school teaches seven classes from Reception to Year 11:

Class	Years	Note
Willow	R, Y1–2	Reception is taught alongside Years 1 and 2; Reception provision is planned against the EYFS framework (see §6)
Hazel	Y3–4	
Oak	Y5–6	Age-sensitive content, including puberty, is taught to the relevant year group rather than the whole class
Maple	Y7–8	
Birch	Y9	Single year group. A bridging year: Key Stage 4 preparation and options
Ash	Y10	Single year group. First year of GCSE courses
Cedar	Y11	Single year group. Second year of GCSE courses, ending in examinations

Because most classes hold two year groups, much of the curriculum runs on rolling cycles so that a pupil spending two years in a class meets different content each year while working toward the same end-points. Birch, Ash and Cedar each hold a single year group, so their programmes are year-specific rather than cyclical. Two-year GCSE courses run across Ash and Cedar, and the handover between them is planned rather than assumed.

4. Breadth: the required areas of experience

As an independent school, Emmanuel is required to provide full-time supervised education giving pupils experience in linguistic, mathematical, scientific, technological, human and social, physical, and aesthetic and creative education. We are not required to follow the National Curriculum, and we do not claim to; we use national age-related expectations as a reference point for breadth and pace where they are useful, and depart from them where our own assessment says our pupils need something different.

Area of experience	Provided through
Linguistic	English (reading, writing, phonics, spelling, speaking and listening); English Language and English Literature at GCSE; French
Mathematical	Mathematics from Reception to GCSE
Scientific	Science from Reception to GCSE
Technological	Computing; Design and Technology; Food Preparation and Nutrition
Human and social	Humanities (History and Geography); Biblical Studies and RE; Growing in Christ (PSHE and RSE); Business Studies; Media Studies
Physical	Physical Education and Games, including swimming; health education within Growing in Christ

Area of experience	Provided through
Aesthetic and creative	Art and Craft; Music; Design and Technology; drama within English; Media Studies

5. Subjects

English

Daily English lessons develop pupils' spoken language, listening, reading, writing, punctuation and vocabulary. Alongside Hamilton Trust resources, literacy is taught in a cross-curricular way. Pupils are taught to speak clearly, convey ideas fluently and confidently, and ask questions. Vocabulary is developed systematically, and pupils are encouraged to read for pleasure and widely. Texts are chosen deliberately rather than inherited, and the reasons for those choices are recorded.

Phonics. We follow the Twinkl Phonics programme, a validated systematic synthetic phonics programme, for our younger pupils. Reception, Year 1 and Year 2 have daily phonics lessons taught by trained staff, and reading books are matched to the sounds taught. Pupils further up the school with phonics gaps receive targeted intervention.

Reading has a high profile. Books are inspiring, varied and age-appropriate. Pupils experience guided reading, whole-class reading and individual reading, with those learning to read at a slower pace heard more frequently. Reading books are book-banded. Comprehension is assessed termly from Year 1. In the secondary years pupils read established authors including Dickens and Shakespeare.

Writing and spelling. Writing is developed through modelled, shared and guided writing, editing and discussion, and pupils write for real purposes. From Reception, pupils are assessed termly through an unaided writing session against age-related expectations, and targets are set. Spelling, high-frequency words and common exception words are taught weekly and reinforced daily in phonics.

Speaking, listening and drama. Pupils take an active part in presentations, topic talks, group discussions, debates and drama, and these opportunities are planned for across the curriculum.

Mathematics

Mathematical skills are taught every day. We use White Rose small steps and Power Maths resources to support our lessons, and teachers use every relevant subject to develop pupils' mathematical fluency. We adopt a mastery approach, aiming for deep and sustainable learning, fluency with number, sound conceptual and procedural understanding, and the resilience to break complex problems into steps.

Pacing is a matter of policy, not of individual judgement. Where our end-of-block assessment shows that pupils have not secured a concept, teachers are authorised to take a consolidation week before moving on. That decision is recorded and reviewed termly. This is the clearest example of assessment directly informing planning across the school.

Science

Science is taught as a separate subject, linked to topic work where appropriate. Pupils are encouraged to be curious about the natural world and to work scientifically — asking questions, using scientific vocabulary, planning and carrying out investigations, and analysing results. Practical work is a substantial part of provision. Required content, including evolution, is taught fully and accurately.

Computing

Computing runs from Reception to Year 11, covering computer science, digital literacy and information technology, including algorithms, programming and data representation. Pupils are taught to understand how systems work rather than only how to operate them, on the principle that a pupil who understands a system is harder to manipulate by one. Online safety — privacy, cyberbullying, security and responsible use of social media — is taught here and reinforced through Growing in Christ.

Humanities: History and Geography

The subject is taught as Humanities to Year 6 and as History and Geography in their own right from Year 7, with History available as a GCSE option from Year 9. Our topic programme is balanced and age-appropriate, and plans show how

each subject is taught, the knowledge and skills covered, and links to other parts of the curriculum. We teach location and place knowledge, weather and climate, and significant historical events, people and places including in our own locality. Trips support and enhance this learning.

Art, Music and Design

Art and Craft. Teaching combines whole-class, individual and group work. Units include time appreciating the work of one or more artists: pupils examine how the artist worked, rehearse the techniques, and produce work of their own. Every pupil produces a self-portrait each September, dated and kept, which forms the school's clearest evidence of progression over time.

Music. Pupils have weekly music lessons, currently using Music Express as a basis, covering listening and appraising, creating and exploring, and singing and performing. Pupils are taught to play a musical instrument and encouraged to play together in ensembles. Singing and musical activity enrich assemblies, plays and the wider life of the school.

Design and Technology. Pupils design and make products that solve real and relevant problems, selecting from a wide range of materials and components including construction materials, textiles and ingredients.

Food Preparation and Nutrition

Cooking lessons teach the principles of nutrition and how to prepare a wide variety of dishes, and pupils learn where food comes from and how it is grown. Key Stage 3 builds knife skills, safe kitchen practice, healthy eating and an introduction to food science. Key Stage 4 follows the AQA GCSE Food Preparation and Nutrition specification, including both non-examined assessments. Food hygiene and safety standards are non-negotiable.

Modern Foreign Languages

From Key Stage 2 we teach French to all children, using the CGP scheme *Salut*; from Year 7 we use Pearson French. Pupils learn to understand and respond to spoken and written French, to speak with increasing confidence and fluency, to write in French at varying length, and to develop an appreciation of a range of writing in French. Language is taught within the culture and history of the countries that speak it. Learning a language raises awareness of the multilingual and multicultural world we live in and gives pupils insight into the lives of others.

Biblical Studies and RE

Our school is underpinned by its Christian ethos. Biblical Studies lessons inform pupils of what the Bible says and give them time to reflect and discuss its meaning. We recognise that God has equipped children with discernment, and we want pupils to search out their own informed understanding of Scripture. In the primary years the emphasis is on the biblical narrative learned in order; in the secondary years pupils meet the questions that narrative raises, including the difficult ones.

Pupils also study other major world religions, and the fact that some people hold no religious belief and follow secular philosophies. **Other faiths are taught accurately, respectfully, and from their own sources.** Pupils in this city will live and work alongside neighbours of other faiths, and a Christian who cannot state another belief in terms its adherents would recognise has no standing to discuss it. This enables pupils to become more knowledgeable, responsible and reflective about other people, their beliefs and the world around them.

Business Studies and Media Studies

Both are offered as GCSE courses from Year 9, taught across Birch, Ash and Cedar.

Business Studies follows the AQA specification in full. Pupils study business in the real world, influences on business, operations, human resources, marketing and finance. Ethics is treated as a question asked in every topic rather than a single unit, which is also what the examination rewards, since roughly four-fifths of the marks sit in unseen case studies.

Media Studies follows the AQA specification in full, including the four areas of the theoretical framework, the Close Study Products, both written papers and the non-examined media production, in which pupils make a product for an intended audience and justify it in a statement of intent. Pupils are taught to ask who made a media text and what they wanted, and to apply that scrutiny evenly, including to media the school approves of.

Physical Education and Games

The school uses nearby public playing fields for outdoor sports including cross country, orienteering and tag rugby, as well as its own outdoor space. The local leisure centre is within walking distance and the school provides swimming lessons to improve water safety and swimming ability. PE is assessed against age-appropriate learning targets. The school enters local sports competitions and events through its membership of the local school sports partnership. Physical activity is not allocated on the basis of sex; classes may be taught separately where that is appropriate, but what is offered is not determined by whether a pupil is a boy or a girl.

Growing in Christ: PSHE, Relationships and Health Education

From September 2026 the school's PSHE, Relationships Education, Relationships and Sex Education and Health Education are delivered through **Growing in Christ**, the school's own programme, replacing previous arrangements. It is mapped to the Department for Education's statutory guidance of July 2025, which came into force on the same date.

The programme runs from Reception to Year 11 across seven strands: identity and belonging; character and wisdom; relationships, family and sexuality; physical, emotional and spiritual wellbeing; safety and digital life; stewardship, money and work; and community, citizenship and justice. Every unit and lesson belongs to a strand and derives from published end-of-phase expectations. Statutory coverage is mapped in full in a coverage grid maintained alongside this policy.

How convictions and respect are held together. Growing in Christ teaches the school's biblical convictions clearly, and teaches accurately what the law of England says, including where these differ. Every person is treated with dignity and respect, and pupils are taught the protected characteristics under the Equality Act 2010 and why the school upholds respect for all people. Pupils learn that respecting a person is not the same as agreeing with every view that person holds, and that this works in both directions. Resources are chosen to support this — including materials from Christian organisations whose position reflects the school's own — and all resources are reviewed by the Headteacher against the same standard of accuracy, legal correctness and respect.

Right of withdrawal. Relationships Education, Health Education and the great majority of RSE carry no right of withdrawal. Parents may withdraw their child from the sex education element, which is identified in the RSE policy, up to three terms before the child turns 16, after which the child may opt in. The RSE policy is published on the school website, reviewed against current guidance, and subject to documented parental consultation.

Pupils' personal faith is never assessed in this or any other subject.

6. Early Years

Our Reception children learn alongside Year 1 and Year 2 pupils in Willow. This mixed-age class enables pupils to grow and thrive with older role models. Activities are set within a Christian framework and incorporate the three prime areas and four specific areas of the EYFS. Activities are differentiated for the different age groups and abilities, with older children given more structured learning. Free play, indoors and outdoors, forms part of every session and is planned so that all areas of development are covered. Staff observe children's interests and levels of development in order to plan timely and relevant learning experiences.

Reception provision is planned and evidenced against the EYFS framework and the Early Learning Goals, not against the programmes followed by Years 1 and 2. Because the three year groups share a room, planning for Years 1 and 2 states what Reception children are doing during that teaching, so the mixed-age classroom is planned for rather than worked around.

7. Inclusion and special educational needs

Teachers set high expectations for every pupil and plan work that challenges and enables each child to reach their potential. The curriculum is designed to provide access and opportunity for all children who attend the school. Where it is necessary to adapt the curriculum to meet the needs of an individual child, we do so in consultation with the child's parents.

Provision for pupils with special educational needs or disabilities complies with the SEND Code of Practice and is led by the SENDCo, working with teachers and parents. Adjustments are made early and without ceremony. Needing support is treated as ordinary rather than exceptional, and a pupil's worth is never treated as a function of attainment. Pupils

who are very able are also planned for: stretch is provision, and gifted pupils are taught that their gifts are given for the good of others as well as themselves.

8. Careers guidance

Pupils from Year 8 upwards receive careers guidance that is accurate, up to date, presented impartially, and in their best interests, enabling them to make informed choices about their future. Guidance runs through the stewardship, money and work strand of Growing in Christ — labour market information and work experience preparation in Year 9, post-16 pathways and the practical business of adult life in Years 10 and 11 — and through Business Studies.

Pupils meet people who do the work, and every honest trade is presented as a calling. A small school is not a small horizon: pupils should leave knowing the range of what is possible, not the range their teachers happen to have followed. A record is kept of careers encounters and provision.

9. Spiritual, moral, social and cultural development, and British values

We create a learning environment that promotes pupils' spiritual, moral, social and cultural development, equipping them with the knowledge, skills, attitudes and values they need to be healthy and respectful citizens. Opportunities run through the curriculum, assemblies and extra-curricular activities: pupils are encouraged to be reflective, to develop and voice opinions through class discussion, to reflect on their own behaviour and develop coping strategies. Achievements are celebrated through termly governor awards and weekly celebration assemblies. Daily whole-school assemblies reinforce belonging, citizenship, respect, and mental, emotional and spiritual wellbeing.

We actively promote the fundamental British values of democracy, the rule of law, individual liberty, and mutual respect and tolerance of those with different faiths and beliefs. Pupils develop an understanding of how citizens influence decision-making through the democratic process; that the freedom to hold other faiths and beliefs is protected in law; that people holding different beliefs from one's own, or none, should be accepted and treated with respect, and that difference should never be the cause of discriminatory behaviour; and of the importance of identifying and combating discrimination.

10. Assessment

Assessment exists to inform teaching. Pupils' learning should be secure and embedded so that they have a firm foundation on which to build.

Formal assessment points. Children are assessed at the end of Reception, Year 2, Year 6 and Year 8. In Years 2, 6 and 8 this includes assessment tests comparable to those used in other schools. Year 1 pupils take the phonics screening check. Reading comprehension is assessed termly from Year 1, and writing termly from Reception. Key Stage 4 pupils sit public examinations.

Recording. Judgements are recorded in **Go4Schools** markbooks. Every subject records against its own published progression statements or, where a subject follows an examination specification, against that specification, using a common four-point scale: 1 Beginning · 2 Developing · 3 Secure · 4 Deepening, where Secure is the expected endpoint. Teachers record only where a task has produced meaningful evidence. Safeguarding information is never recorded in Go4Schools; it is recorded in CPOMS only.

Progression is against our own expectations. Each subject publishes end-of-phase expectations describing what pupils secure by the end of each phase, and assessment is against those. National age-related expectations inform them but do not govern them.

The review loop. Each term the subject lead, with the senior leadership team, reviews the markbook by class and cohort, identifies gaps, adjusts teaching and records the adjustment made. The record of what changed in response is the evidence that assessment informs planning. Subject leaders also sample pupils' work and report to governors on progress.

11. How we implement this

Quality first teaching

Highly focused lesson design with clear objectives, and high levels of interaction for all children.

Appropriate use of teacher questioning, modelling and explaining.

An expectation that children develop resilience, accept responsibility for their own learning, and work independently.

Regular encouragement and praise.

Target setting and intervention

Individual progress tracked in all year groups; strengths and weaknesses identified to support planning.

Children have regular opportunities to discuss their progress and are involved in setting and reviewing targets.

Pupils not making sufficient progress are identified quickly; provision is mapped to need, planned, delivered and evaluated.

Parents and carers are regularly updated on their child's progress.

Learning environment

Classrooms adapted to children's learning needs, with effective use of the outdoor classroom, library and hall.

Displays combine celebration of children's work with supportive resources and information; cultural diversity is represented.

Books are readily available and well resourced to inspire a love of reading.

Extended curriculum and partnership with parents

Visits into the local community, and visiting speakers and professionals who share knowledge and inspire.

Sporting fixtures against other schools, allowing for competitive sport.

Twice-yearly parent consultations, a written report in the summer term, and workshops on phonics, number, healthy eating and internet safety.

12. Impact

We aim for pupils to leave Emmanuel with a character shaped by the principles of the Christian faith — a love for God, a servant heart, a forgiving spirit and a hardworking ethic — and with a secure understanding of the academic content of their courses. We aim for them to understand how to be socially, morally, spiritually and culturally responsible, safe and globally aware, to make positive contributions to the local area, and to leave respectful, skilful and ambitious.

We judge whether that is happening by: examination and assessment outcomes measured against pupils' own starting points; progress recorded in Go4Schools and reviewed termly; the record of curriculum changes made in response to that review; sampling of pupils' work by subject leaders; pupil voice; destinations of leavers; and the September portrait sequence in art, which shows each pupil their own progression year on year. Where a measure does not yet exist for a subject, developing one is part of that subject's current work.

13. Roles, monitoring and review

Class teachers embed the teaching and learning and assessment policies, ensure coverage and assessment of the agreed objectives, liaise with subject leaders, and adapt teaching for the range of abilities in the class.

Subject leaders maintain their subject's rationale and progression expectations, monitor planning and pupils' work, lead the termly markbook review, and report to governors.

The senior leadership team monitors planning, conducts work scrutiny and learning walks, quality-assures subject rationales, and feeds back to individual teachers so that strengths are shared and development points acted on.

Governors receive termly reports on curriculum progress and review this policy annually.

This policy was reviewed by the Governing Body on 1st October 2026 and will be reviewed annually.